

A Difficult Journey

By the 1870s almost all immigrants traveled by steamship. The trip across the Atlantic Ocean from Europe took approximately one week. The Pacific crossing from Asia took nearly three weeks. Many immigrants traveled in steerage, the cheapest accommodations in a ship's cargo holds. Immigrants were crowded together in the gloom. They were rarely allowed on deck, so they could not exercise or catch a breath of fresh air. They often had to sleep in bunks infested with lice and share toilets with many other passengers. Under these conditions, disease spread quickly. Some immigrants died before they reached their destination. For those who survived, the first glimpse of America could be breathtaking.

THE VOYAGE

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Steerage is "The part of a passenger ship allotted to those passengers who travel at the cheapest rate." A benign definition, surely, suggesting modest but adequate below-deck accommodations for thrifty travelers. But for millions of our immigrant ancestors, this experience would haunt the rest of their days.

As diverse as were the immigrant peoples, the horrors of the midpassage were grimly similar. For up to two weeks on the Atlantic, as many as 900 souls were crammed into steerage, each allotted little more space than their body dimensions. Russian Jew or Irishman, Greek or German, man, woman, or child, the fetid underdecks of the slowly moving ships reduced individuals to an undifferentiated, suffering mass.

Here and there, a ship's travelers had the good fortune of a tolerable passage. Everywhere, moments of youthful hope transcended reality. In the years after 1900, steerage conditions tended to improve, and travel time shrank to a more tolerable six or seven days. Yet relative suffering is suffering nonetheless, as the large literature of steerage recollections makes so wrenchingly clear.

"Before the emigrant has been a week at sea he is an altered man. How can it be otherwise? Hundreds of poor people, men, women, and children, of all ages, from the drivelling idiot of ninety to the babe just born, huddled together without light, without air, wallowing in filth and breathing a fetid atmosphere, sick in body, dispirited in heart, the fevered patients lying between the sound, in sleeping places so narrow as almost to deny them the power of indulging, by a change of position, the natural restlessness of the disease; by their agonised ravings disturbing those around, and predisposing them, through the effects of the imagination, to imbihe the contagion; living without food or medicine, except as administered by the hand of casual charity, dying without the voice of spiritual consolation, and buried in the deep without the rites of the church."

These are the words of Stephen de Vere, a landowner and philanthropist from County Limerick, a distant relative of the former Earls of Oxford, a convert to Rome, and a poet who translated Horace's Odes. He saved Irishmen from the gallows, taught in Irish schools, charged his tenants less than a fair rent for his lands, and for more than twenty years abstained from wine to encourage temperance among the poor. In 1847 he went out to America not in the cabin but as a steerage passenger, to see for himself how poor emigrants were treated.

The most detailed account of all is by an Irish gentleman, Vere Foster, who was no relation of Stephen de Vere, and must not be confused with him. Foster sailed in the *Washington*, which left Liverpool for New York in October 1850. This was not a year of great disease. The passage was not stormy, although it was winter. The *Washington*

was no hulk, but one of the finest American emigrant ships. She was new, strong, and dry. Her two passenger decks were each over seven feet high, and bulwarks more than six feet high protected the deck from sea spray. She had a crew of thirty-one sailors, three boys, four mates, and a captain. She carried a surgeon. She was a great deal better in all ways than the average run of emigrant ships. She left Liverpool on October 25 with 934 passengers and anchored in the Mersey to take on supplies. Next day Foster went on board to sail as one of the cabin passengers. He was the man who had given away 250,000 copies of his *Emigrants' Guide*. He was a philanthropist, and a relative of Lord Hobart, who was with the Board of Trade in London.

One of the first things Foster saw on board was the doling out of the daily water ration. All 900 or so passengers were called forward at once to receive the water, which was pumped into their cans from barrels on deck. The serving out was twice conspicuously stopped by the mates, who cursed, abused, kicked, and cuffed the passengers and their tin cans and, having served about thirty people, said there would be no more water that day. Foster gently remonstrated with one of the mates, observing to him that such treatment was highly improper and unmanly, and that the mate would save himself a great deal of trouble and annoyance and win, instead of alienating, the hearts of the passengers, if he would avoid foul language and brutal treatment: the mate replied that if Foster said another word he would knock him down. By October 30, no food at all had been served to the passengers although the contract tickets stated they were to be fed each day. The poorer steerage passengers had brought nothing with them, and for five days had nothing to eat except what they could beg from their better-off companions. Foster began to write

shut his eyes to it, thinking he could not make people virtuous if they were disposed to be immoral. . . .

Sylvester Redmond, journalist, was asked if he thought indiscriminate intercourse took place. He said: 'I saw on two occasions, in the daytime, persons in very indelicate positions.'

'Of different sexes?'—'Yes.'

This is risible; as it was when a captain in the Royal Navy was solemnly questioned about unmarried men on board being able to 'view the married women dressing or undressing, and see what is going on'. He had to agree that there was 'use given to the eyes'. But this berthing together must have been intolerable for a modest woman. Sometimes women had to sit up all night on boxes because they could not think of going to bed with strange men, under the blanket.

The women got the worst of it in other ways. Those who had no men to look out for them found it difficult to get any food at all. A doctor who had made many voyages from Liverpool to America said that on rough days he had often been obliged to go into the steerage with buckets of water and a bag of biscuits to feed the women to save them from starvation. Women and feeble men went days without a bite. A boarding-house keeper at Liverpool who had made one voyage on a ship with about 400 passengers, said that there was only room for six people to stand and cook at the same time, and there was incessant cooking and fighting from six in the morning till six at night. 'The women particularly, who were alone, must have wanted their food.' . . .

. . . On many Irish ships the staple diet was a coarse concoction of wheat, barley, rye, and pease, which became saturated with moisture on board ship, where it fermented and became baked into a solid mass 'requiring to be broken down with an axe before using'.

Many emigrants would not eat unaccustomed food, though it might have been perfectly good.

The Irish, although preferring potatoes, which they never got, would eat oatmeal. The English, thinking it food for horses, would not. One passenger said he had seen it thrown into the *St. Lawrence*. He had seen the river covered with oatmeal. Many emigrants were too poor and ignorant to know what to do with the food they were given. One captain said a third of them did not know what tea was. 'It is no uncommon thing to see an Irishman survey his allowance of tea for a while, and then fill his pipe with a portion, and smoke it with evident satisfaction.'

. . . On September 3, 1853, Delaney Finch, a farmer, sailed from Liverpool to Quebec in the *Fingal*, with 200 other passengers and 1,100 tons of railroad iron. She was lost on the return voyage. Finch said she was a good ship, though the berths broke down. On the voyage of seven weeks, thirty-seven or forty-one passengers died; he could not remember which. Later he was asked what happened. He said: 'I should not like to give an opinion, but my impression is, that Epsom salts and castor oil are very improper medicines to administer to persons labouring under the cholera.'

'Is that what they gave?'—'Yes.'

'Epsom salts and castor oil?'—'Yes, and thirty-five drops of laudanum, and then rubbing a man's face with vinegar.'

He was asked if any record was kept of the deaths: 'When we got to Quebec, I and Mr. Liefchild, a gentleman who was in the second cabin, had to put down the names of the parties who died on the voyage, but it was more guess-work than certainty.'

Then he was asked how the burials were carried out, and he said the bodies were thrown overboard, not covered up or anything.

'Did he [the captain] give directions to have the corpse sewn up in canvas, and thrown over?'—'No, he did not use his jurisdiction in that matter, because he said in the cabin, "We are not bound to do it; it is only according to courtesy."'